

The Faithful DEPARTED

The ouster of a former MP for practising his religion is likely to further distance the minorities from the CPI(M)

By M.G. Radhakrishnan

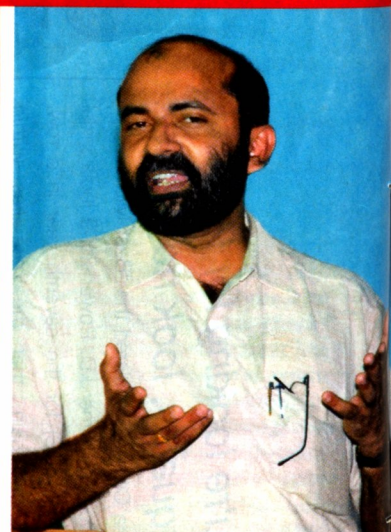
Last week, as Jyoti Basu lay fighting for life in the intensive cardiac care unit of the AMRI Hospital in Kolkata, a group of ethnic Pashtuns and Christian priests took turns to offer Muslim and Christian prayers outside the hospital for the speedy recovery of the 96-year-old CPI(M) patriarch. Around the same time, in the country's other Red bastion, Kerala, a prominent Catholic communist had just walked out of the CPI(M) in protest against a party diktat to its workers to refrain from participating in any religious ritual. K.S. Manoj, 45, a former MP and a prominent leader of the Latin Catholic Association, says he could not comply with the recent "rectification document" brought out by the CPI(M) Politburo. "I am deeply religious and cannot sever my links with the Church or its rituals," says Manoj, a physician who was roped into politics by the CPI(M) in the 2004 elections. He contested from the Alappuzha Lok Sabha seat and won it, but lost in 2009.

This comes close on the heels of three-time MP A.P. Abdullakutty's expulsion, who left the party after being censured for his participation in religious rituals. The CPI(M) groomed Abdullakutty for his wide connections within the community that was traditionally pro-Muslim League, but he infuriated the party by participating in Eid prayers and making a pilgrimage to Mecca. As if all these weren't blasphemous enough, Abdullakutty also had the verve to praise Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi's

economic policies. He was sacked in January last year. But he had the last laugh in the Kannur Assembly by-elections two months ago; he contested on a Congress ticket and trounced the CPI(M) candidate. "Manoj's resignation vindicates me. It is impossible for those who believe in God to remain in the party," says Abdullakutty, 42.

These ousters have considerably jolted the CPI(M), for both leaders belong to minority communities that the CPI(M) had been desperately wooing without much success. In fact, both were roped in and elevated to key posts specifically to send a

Some bishops even say that Christians in Kerala would



THE RELIGIOUS CREDENTIALS OF A.P. ABDULLAKUTTY (LEFT) AND K.S. MANOJ CAME IN HANDY FOR THE CPI(M) TO WOO THE MINORITIES. IRONICALLY, THEY HAVE BEEN SHOWN THE DOOR FOR INSISTING THAT THEY WILL PRACTICE THEIR RELIGION.

